THE BENEDICT YEAR

Montessori and the atrium

Montessori shapes the day and how mistakes are found; the Catechesis of the Good Shepherd shapes the year's prayer. Neither keeps score.

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Maria Montessori shapes how the day runs and how mistakes are found. The Catechesis of the Good Shepherd shapes the year's prayer and its God and Worship units. Both refuse prizes. Montessori called prizes and punishments "the bench of the soul" (*The Montessori Method*, 1912, chapter I). The Catechesis asks the catechist to give up quizzes, tests and exams, because Christ is the only teacher. That is why they fit Mr. Benedict: none of them keeps score.

The work period

Each morning is one long work period, uninterrupted. The Association Montessori Internationale's elementary standard is three hours, though its own answer is that there is no magic in the number three: the rule is not to break in on the child. The day's Benedict presentation opens the morning. Then the child chooses from the shelf: the week's mathematics, the unit's materials, the essay, his own writing.

Control of error

Montessori wrote that her didactic material "contains within itself the control of errors" (chapter XXII). The cylinder that will not fit its socket shows the mistake, and no adult has to. The book's problems need the same thing, and the answer key, used by the child himself, is the simplest form of it. Mathematics runs in three steps: from the material, to the book's problem, to the child checking his own answer.

MATERIAL	WHAT IT SHOWS	WHERE IT MEETS THE BOOK
Bead chains, short and long	Skip counting to n^2 and n^3: a chain folds into its square, and its squares stack into its cube	Exponents; Unit 2's 2 + 4 + 8 + 16
Binomial and trinomial cubes	$(a + b)^3$ and $(a + b + c)^3$ as wooden blocks	*Prealgebra*'s algebra
Checkerboard	Place value and partial products	The properties of arithmetic
Fraction insets	Equivalence, and unlike denominators at 9 to 12	3/4 + 5/6, and why 8/10 is wrong
Constructive triangles; the Pythagorean plates	Congruence, similarity and area; the 3:4:5 and general cases	Geometry, and Unit 4's similar triangles

The Great Stories

Montessori elementary classrooms open each year with five stories, told to spark research rather than to teach details. They fall on the map. Montessori classrooms tell all five at the start of the year, and so does this one: the Story of the Universe (Mario Montessori's "God Who Has No Hands") on the first day, then the other four, in order, over the first weeks. Each comes back with its unit.

GREAT STORY	UNIT
The Story of the Universe	Day 1; again in 7 Being: God known from his effects
Communication in Signs	1 Reading
The Story of Numbers	2 Number
The Coming of Life	3 Nature
The Coming of Human Beings: a thinking mind, a working hand, a loving heart	6 The Person

The atrium

The Catechesis's Level III (ages 9 to 12) centres on the Plan of God. The atrium meets at least once a week for two hours or more, led by a parent formed in the Catechesis. Formation takes time (about 90 hours for Level I, 96 for Level II and 110 to 120 for Level III), so until then a parish atrium can carry this part. Nothing in the atrium is measured, and the Friday test never enters it. Its presentations fall on the map too.

UNIT	IN THE ATRIUM
1 Reading	Typology: a close reading of a Hebrew Scripture text, then its types in Redemption. The types stop short of the Parousia
4 Making	The Story of Bread: wheat, bread, Eucharist
5 Memory	The History of the Kingdom of God and the Plan of God: a long ribbon from creation to redemption, a blank white stretch for the future, and an end with no date
6 The Person	The True Vine, Level II work that Level III takes up: the moral life as the fruit of life in the Vine
7 Being	Cosmic Education and the introduction to the Plan of God; with Sofia Cavalletti, creation as a gift that asks a response
8 God	The Holy Bible and the Parousia; the prophets; several translations in the prayer corner
9 The Act	The moral parables (the Ten Bridesmaids, the Talents, the Debtors), the further Maxims, the Virtues
10 The City	The Peoples and the People of God; the Kingdom of God and my place in it
11 Law	Typology of Moses, the Exodus and the Law
12 Worship	The Structure of the Mass, the Second Missal, the expanded liturgical calendar, the complete Order of Baptism, and the Memorial, given to the oldest children: were we born too late to be at the Last Supper?

The Catechesis's levels end at 12, so for a 12- or 13-year-old this is the atrium's last year. It is not a published curriculum, and its finished materials are not sold. The presentations are given by someone formed in them, and the materials are made by hand.

The adult

Montessori's adult prepares the environment and observes. The catechist is "the useless servant" (Luke 17:10) and listens with the child. So Mr. Benedict's tests change hands: the parent notes what the child's reasons show, and nothing is marked.

Going out, and the land

In 10 The City and 11 Law the child plans a going-out the Montessori way: he finds what his work needs, arranges the visit himself, and reports back. A council meeting, the parish office, a courtroom. For 12 and up, Montessori's *Erdkinder* ("earth children") pictured adolescents farming, keeping a shop and a guest house, and taking machines apart in a "museum of machinery". A small stall with one posted price is Unit 9's essay put to work: a market you could send a child to.

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